CK RECORD

Several of DRDO's big-ticket 'Mission Mode' projects are running behind schedule, but there are others that are deemed great successes. Here are some of the prominent ones in each category



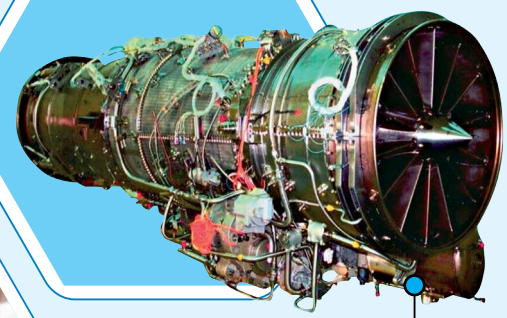
LIGHT COMBAT AIRCRAFT (LCA), MARK-II

Scheduled for **2008**

Status: Could be ready for maiden flight by 2025

Budget: **₹11,500 cr.**

Given the delay in LCA Tejas Mk-II, the IAF will have to fill the void in medium multirole fighers and replace its ageing Mirage 2000s



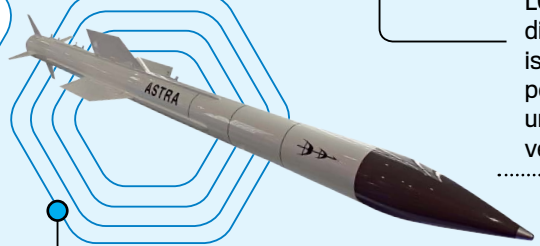
AERO-ENGINE KAVERI

Scheduled for **Dec. '96**

Status: France is expected to help bolster Kaveri

Budget **₹2,100 cr.**

Kaveri turbofan engine was meant to power LCA Tejas, but ran into difficulties. Now, a variant is being prepared to power DRDO's stealth unmanned combat air vehicle Ghatak



ASTRA AIR-TO-AIR MISSILE

Scheduled for **Aug. 2012**

Budget: **₹955 cr.**

Status: IAF plans to arm its frontline fighters with the Astra MK-I by 2023-end

Astra is a family of beyond-visual-range air-to-air missiles. It has a launch range of 100 km. Project initiated in 1990, limited production of Astra Mk-I missiles started in 2017. A longer-range Mk-II version is under development

SOME TRIUMPHS

ARJUN TANK

Arjun is a third-generation main battle tank developed by the Combat Vehicles Research and Development Establishment of DRDO. Arjun, first planned in 1972, was meant to replace the Russian T-72 that is still in service. The 43rd Armoured Regiment, formed in 2009, was the first to receive Arjuns



AGNI MISSILE

Agni missiles are long-range cruise missiles developed under the Integrated Ballistic Missile Development Programme. Work on the Agni missile series began in 1982-83; Agni I was tested in 1989. The latest is Agni V, which has a strike range of 7,000 km. In June 2023, the new generation 'Agni Prime' was flight-tested

LCA TEJAS

The LCA, India's own fighter jet, originated in 1983 with the goal to develop a new light combat aircraft to replace ageing IAF fighters, especially MiG-21 variants. Its maiden flight was completed on January 4, 2001. In 2016, Tejas was inducted into the IAF, which operates 40 Tejas and is waiting for the delivery of 83 LCA Mk-1A

PRALAY MISSILE

Short-range ballistic missile with a range of 150-200 km. Equipped with advanced avionics, it can avert interceptor missiles, change direction midway. Underwent first trial in 2021; in Sept. 2023, MoD approved their deployment on the LoC and LAC

2008. It suggested that the DRDO should concentrate only on "core technologies of strategic importance". The committee had suggested making it a leaner organisation. This was done by rearranging DRDO's 52 labs into clusters based on technology domains like missiles, electronic warfare, radars, aerial vehicles and underwater weapons. In 2015, Rao Inderjit Singh, the then minister of state for defence production, stated in Parliament that the DRDO had implemented all the recommendations made by the P. Rama Rao Committee that were within its power. The first panel to look into the DRDO was set up in 1992-93, and was led by the late A.P.J. Abdul Kalam during his tenure as DRDO chief. It came out with a decade-long roadmap to elevate indigenous production in defence equipment from the existing 30 per cent to 70 per cent by 2005.

DAMNING DELAYS

In February 2023, the MoD informed Parliament that out of DRDO's 55 'mission mode' projects, 23 were running behind schedule. Mission mode projects are high-priority tasks that use accessible technologies. As of date, DRDO's mission mode projects have a total sanctioned cost of Rs 73,942.8 crore. Some areas under research are torpedo decoy systems, nuclear de-